DR. NIKITA MEHTA

BEFORE YOU GET COMPOSITE BONDING

What good bonding looks like, and the questions worth asking



ALIGNMENT, WHITENING AND BONDING · MY OWN CASE

Bonding is one of the kindest ways to change a smile. It adds to your teeth rather than taking away, and done well, it can be hard to tell it's there. Done quickly, it can look bulky and flat. This guide explains what makes the difference, so you can ask the right questions.

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STEP 1

IS BONDING *right for you?*

DR. NM

Composite is a tooth-coloured material added to your teeth and shaped by hand. It needs little or no shaping of your own tooth, which is why I often suggest it before anything more permanent.

IT WORKS WELL FOR

- chipped or worn edges
- small gaps
- teeth that are uneven in length or shape
- refreshing old, stained fillings on front teeth

IT MAY NOT BE THE FIRST STEP IF

- your teeth are crowded or crooked, as straightening first usually gives a more natural result with less composite
- your bite is wearing your teeth down, as the bite needs looking at first or the bonding is likely to chip
- you'd like whiter teeth, as composite doesn't whiten, so whitening comes first and the bonding is matched to it

> **WORTH KNOWING**
> A lot of my bonding cases start with clear aligners and whitening. The bonding is the last step, not the first.

STEP 2

WHAT GOOD BONDING *looks like*

DR. NM

When bonding is done well, it looks like a tooth that was always there. These are the things I look for in my own work, and that you can look for in anyone's photos.

1 **IT'S NOT BULKY**

The teeth shouldn't look thicker or pushed forward.

2 **THE EDGES LOOK NATURAL**

Real teeth are slightly translucent at the edge, with soft corners. Flat, opaque edges give bonding away.

3 **IT SUITS THE FACE**

The two front teeth match, but the teeth beside them aren't copies. Shapes change around the arch.

4 **THE GUMS LOOK HEALTHY AROUND IT**

Bonding should finish smoothly at the gum, so it's easy to clean.



ALIGNMENT, WHITENING, BONDING



ALIGNMENT, WHITENING, BONDING



ALIGNMENT, WHITENING, COMPOSITE

MY OWN CASES. EACH ONE STARTED WITH ALIGNMENT AND WHITENING.

YOUR CONSULTATION

QUESTIONS *to ask*

DR. NM

1 **CAN I SEE YOUR OWN BONDING CASES, CLOSE UP?**

Close-ups show the edges and the finish.

2 **WOULD YOU STRAIGHTEN OR WHITEN FIRST?**

If the answer is always "no", ask why.

3 **HOW MUCH OF MY TOOTH WILL YOU SHAPE?**

For most bonding, little or none.

4 **WHAT HAPPENS TO MY BITE?**

Your dentist should check it before and after.

5 **HOW LONG WILL IT LAST, AND WHAT DOES LOOKING AFTER IT INVOLVE?**

An honest answer includes maintenance.

"I always ask: does it look like them? Bonding should fit the person, not a trend."

STEP 3

LIVING WITH *your bonding*

DR. NM

Composite is strong, but it isn't porcelain. It needs a little care to keep looking its best.

DO	AVOID
Brush twice a day and clean between your teeth every day.	Biting hard things with your front teeth: nails, pens, ice, bottle tops.
Come in for your maintenance visit every year, when I polish and check the bonding.	Very staining habits straight after treatment (coffee, red wine, smoking), as composite can pick up stain over time.
Wear a night guard if you clench or grind, and I've made you one.	

HOW LONG DOES IT LAST?

With care, bonding can look good for years. In my experience, where several teeth are bonded, it can start to look tired after about five to six years and may need refreshing or replacing. That's normal for composite, and it's why maintenance matters.

GOING FURTHER

WHEN BONDING *isn't enough*

DR. NM

Sometimes bonding is a stepping stone, and sometimes the teeth need more. If teeth are badly worn, heavily filled or very discoloured, porcelain veneers or crowns may last longer. I'd talk you through each option, including the trade-offs, so you can choose.



TWO VENEERS WHERE THE TEETH NEEDED THEM, BONDING EVERYWHERE ELSE

TALK IT THROUGH

If you'd like to talk about your smile, book a consultation with me through my website.

BOOK A CONSULTATION

DRNIKITAMEHTA.COM

KEEP READING

I write *The Deliberate Clinician*, a free weekly letter on how I think about smiles, ageing and the work behind a natural result.

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